BRITISH COUNCIL

English Online

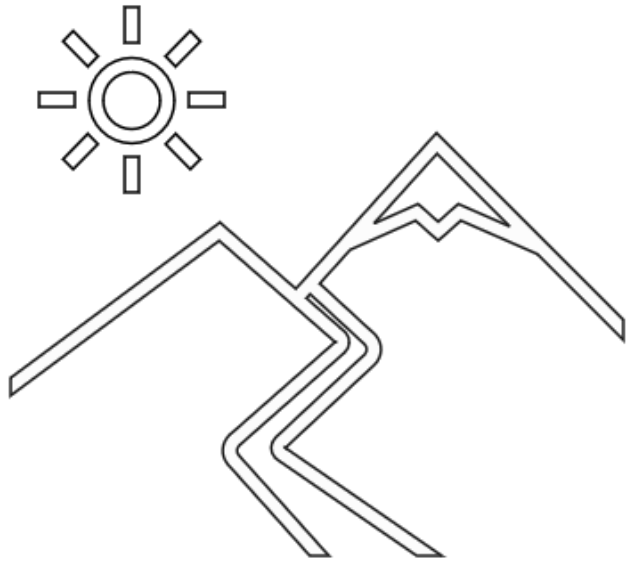
LIVE25

Pronunciation: the power of the pause

Introduction

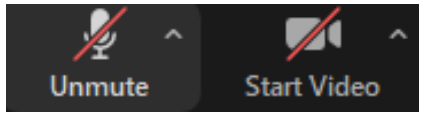
Welcome to Pronunciation Live25!

- **A new feature of English Online**
- **Free pronunciation presentations**
- **Download the PDF after booking**
- **Practise on mute**
- **Sit back and enjoy the ride!**



Please be on mute

You can keep your cams off



Lead-in

Have you….heard a speaker….who uses….**pause**…for dramatic effect?



Why do they do it?
What is that effect?
Write the first thing that comes to you mind in the chat box.

Who do you know who does it best?
Write their name or profession in the chat box.

Let’s focus



Some orators (professional speakers) use pause for very specific reasons.

To….*control* what the audience *hears and listens* to.

To…..*lead* the listener and have them *follow*.

To…..*persuade* an audience to follow them.



When listening, an audience can't see punctuation, so it has to be communicated verbally. In English, we do this with pauses.

Pauses allow you to punctuate spoken words, giving listeners clues as to when one phrase, one complete thought, one paragraph of ideas ends, and the next begins.

Form

In written English, the comma signals a pause and the full stop the end of a thought. A comma is used mid sentence, between ideas that are incomplete.

A taxi driver, who had only recently been married, was working late one night in the city, a place which was very familiar to him, when he was involved in a terrifying confrontation.

How many commas are there in the sentence?

Write the number in the chatbox.

Meaning and use

A **pause** is a form of **oral punctuation** that can help your audience reflect on what you just said.

A sudden silence can have the same effect as a sudden loud noise.

It alerts your audience and makes them attentive to **what you say next.**

Practice

On mute, read aloud the following text from F.Scott Fitgerald's *The Great Gatsby*. Slow down. Enjoy the imagery.

First read the passage quickly, without pause.

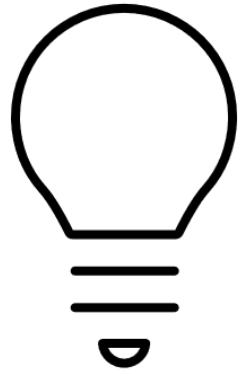
Then a second time, pausing to allow for reflection, and anticipation of what will come next. Be aware of the punctuation, including the conjunctions.

There was music from my neighbor's house through the summer nights.// In his blue gardens // men and girls came and went like moths among the whisperings and the champagne and the stars.// At high tide in the afternoon I watched his guests diving from the tower of his raft // or taking the sun on the hot sand of his beach while his two motor-boats slit the waters of the Sound, // drawing aquaplanes over cataracts of foam. // On week-ends his Rolls-Royce became an omnibus, // bearing parties to and from the city, // between nine in the morning and long past midnight,// while his station wagon scampered like a brisk yellow bug to meet all trains.//

Key point

Pausing will create anticipation and expectation, and is a highly effective device to use when speaking English.

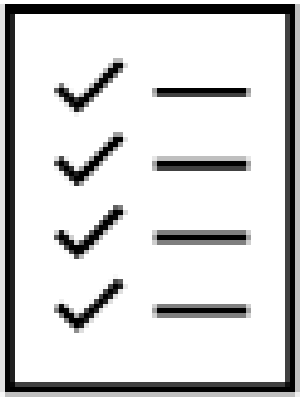
Pronunciation tip: **Pause at the commas, and stop at the full stops.**



Pronunciation Checkout

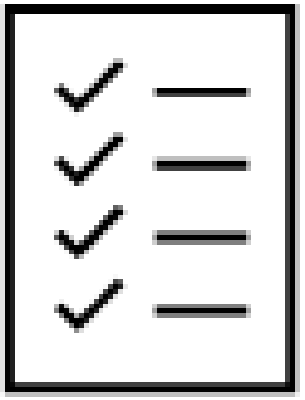
1. **Pausing is like a form of …….. .**
2. **Commas appear in the …… of the sentence, and full stops at the …… .**
3. **Pausing allows us to anticipate what will happen ……. .**

next….after….before….punctuation….grammar….speech….centre….start….middle….beginning….end



Pronunciation Checkout - Answers

1. **Pausing is like a form of punctuation.**
2. **Commas appear in the middle of the sentence, and full stops at the end.**
3. **Pausing allows us to anticipate what will happen next .**



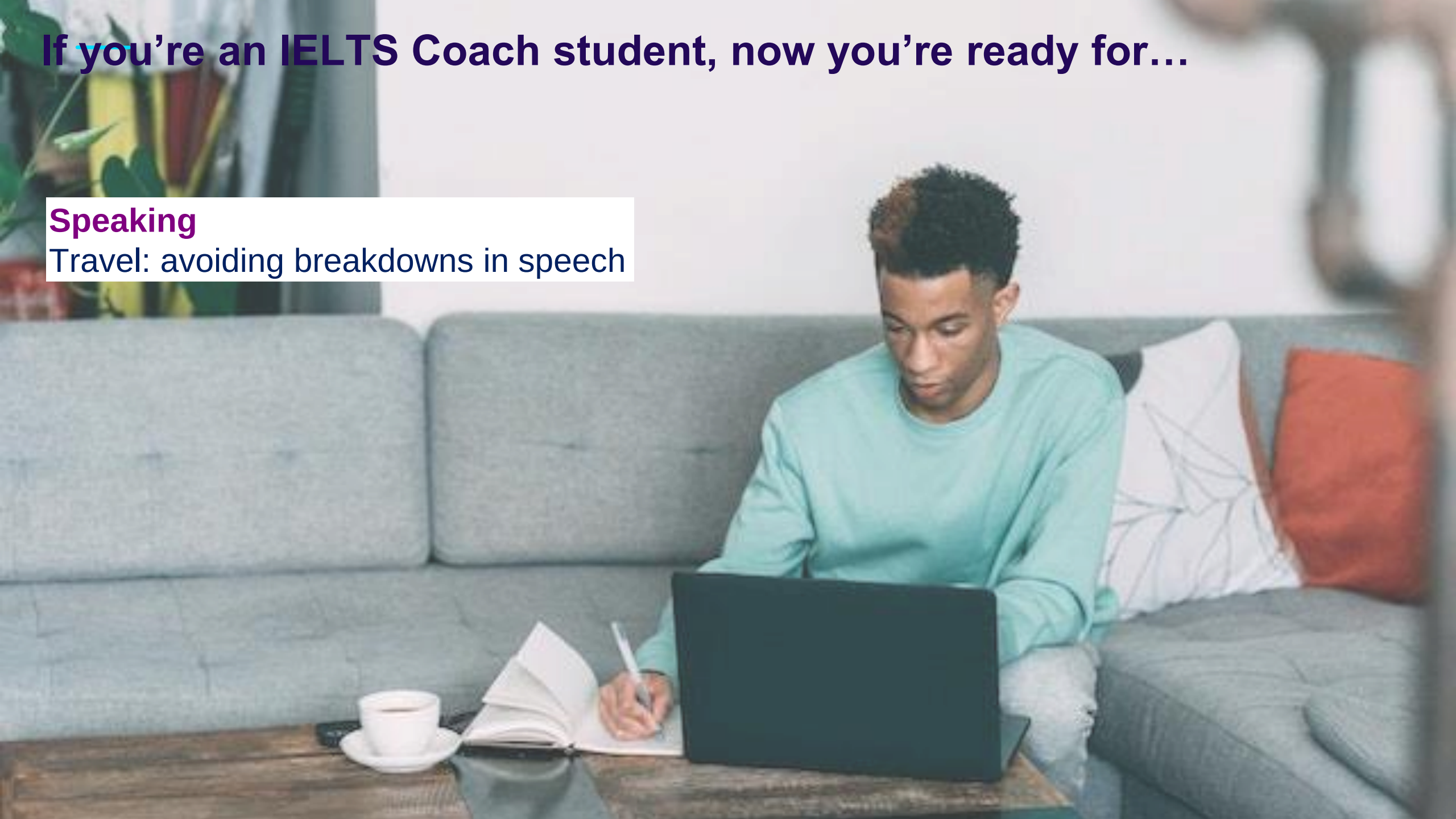
Thank you for attending this presentation!

Review the next few slides for lessons linked to this Live25 webinar.



https://www.bbc.com/worklife/article/20170718-the-subtle-power-of-uncomfortable-silences

If you’re an IELTS Coach student, now you’re ready for…



Speaking

Travel: avoiding breakdowns in speech

If you’re an English Online student, now you’re ready for…



Elementary
Theme: Things around us
Lesson: My home

Pre-intermediate
Theme: Technology
Lesson: Office equipment

Intermediate
Theme: Presentation and processes
Lesson: Giving a presentation

Upper intermediate
Theme: Presentations
Lesson: Making a case

Advanced
Theme: Business communication
Lesson: Current tendencies

If you’re an English for Work student, now you’re ready for…



Elementary
Theme: Your background
Lesson: Your ideal job

Pre-intermediate
Theme: A new position
Lesson: Describing yourself

Intermediate
Theme: Ready to work
Lesson: Strengths and weaknesses

Upper intermediate
Theme: Working with clients
Lesson: Your ideal company

Advanced
Theme: Product research and development
Lesson: Data and information